hardens people. Difficult times expose who people are at their core. You must be realistic. Things will get worse before they get better."

"How can they get any worse?" She sounded like the eighteen-year-old she'd been when she first stepped inside his office.

"Because one side will eventually win and the other will lose, and there will be much suffering in between. Think carefully about your next steps. Do what is best for you and Rose." He stood. "If you are in trouble, come to my home and I'll do what I can to help."

"Thank you." Léa embraced him quickly, turning away and thundering down the stairs so he wouldn't see the emotion welling up in her chest.

It was dark as she rushed along the sidewalk, tears streaming down her face. Their discussion had delayed her departure and left her feeling confused and disoriented. She had always admired Maître Mallon, seen him almost like the father she'd lost when she was just a child. He'd told her of his own struggles, how he'd come from a broken family and worked hard to achieve success as a notary. He'd been a beacon, reassuring her that there was order to the world and if she applied herself, she too could attain a better life.

She couldn't stop thinking about his warning—that times would get more difficult and that she must protect Rose. Léa thought of her mother's refrain whenever Léa came to her with a problem or had lost patience with Rose. *Keep a good heart.* That was her challenge—how to get through the war and keep her heart good. She would find a way to do that—she had to, not just to honor her mother but to be an example to Rose.

Léa wiped her nose with her sleeve and stopped to tie her shoelaces. Then, tightening her collar against the cold, she felt the change in the air. Last winter there hadn't been enough coal to heat the boardinghouse, so she and Rose huddled at night under one blanket, their bodies warming one another. If she didn't find work, how would they get through this winter? Madame Martin had already raised the rent, which the other women could pay with their higher salaries. Léa negotiated, in lieu of the extra francs, that Rose would tend the chickens. But what if she raised the rent again? Léa bit her lower lip. She'd been trying to hold things together, but as she passed the dusty, bombed-out streets, she suddenly felt like her world was splintering, and who would help her hold it all together?

The moon shone a gritty light on the boardinghouse up ahead. Waiting